ostensibly to lead a Tibetan delegation to an event to celebrate the inauguration of the first constitution of the People's Republic of China. Only 19 years old, he met all the important Chinese leaders of the time: Mao Zedong, Zhou Enlai, and Deng Xiaoping. Pictures of a smiling Dalai Lama with his seemingly friendly Chinese hosts were published in the official media, but Mao insulted the spiritual leader by telling him that religion was poison. Mao also told him that an entirely new body, the Preparatory Committee for the Autonomous Region of Tibet, was being created, effectively undermining the promises made under 17-point agreement of 1951. The Tibetans could forget about managing their own affairs.

When the Dalai Lama returned home to Lhasa, he found that the Chinese had built new roads into Tibet, including highways down to towns close to the Indian border. There were more PLA soldiers in the country than when he had left for Beijing. The Dalai Lama was distraught, realizing that whatever autonomy his beloved Tibet had enjoyed since the Chinese first entered Tibet would soon be gone. The Chinese were the new overlords. And the Communists would be much less tolerant of religious practices than their predecessors, Imperial China and the KMT, could ever have been had they extended their rule over Tibet.

There was an opening when, in late 1956, the Dalai Lama went on a pilgrimage to India. It was Buddha Jayanti, the birthday of the Buddha, and he received an official invitation from Jawaharlal Nehru to attend the celebrations at Bodh Gaya, where the Mahabodhi temple had been renovated for the event. The Dalai Lama and a 55-man strong Tibetan delegation entered India through Sikkim. But, to their astonishment, they found that Zhou Enlai was also in India on an official visit.

The Tibet issue was discussed and Nehru summoned the Dalai Lama to New Delhi. There would be no asylum for him in India, should he decide to escape from Chinese-dominated Tibet. India's new-won friendship with China was far more important and vital to the political stability of the entire region, the Indian prime minister had concluded. The Dalai Lama returned to Tibet, advised to do so by his two official soothsayers.[101]

It is not clear how much the Dalai Lama knew about the anti-Chinese resistance that was being formed or whether even Nehru was aware of what the CIA agents in Kolkata and their two royal Sikkimese lady friends were up to. In September 1952, the US consul general in Kolkata, Gary Soulen,